Beyond the Coastline

Contents

[English text unavailable] 2
[English text unavailable] 5
[English text unavailable] 9
[English text unavailable] 10
[English text unavailable] 12
[English text unavailable] 15
[English text unavailable] 16
[English text unavailable] 18
[English text unavailable] 21
[English text unavailable] 23
[English text unavailable] 24

[English text unavailable]

COL-310801

VIP Barrel Seat

Deck, "Free Breeze" Cruise Ship

Cruise Ticket Seller: Ladies and gentlemen, it's time to make your choice!

Cruise Ticket Seller: The clock's ticking! There is but half an hour left until tonight's performance. Hurry up and select your favorite pieces!

Cruise Ticket Seller: Admiring the scenery, eh, signore? You can leave your song request form with me, if you're ready.

Guest: It's all thanks to you! I almost missed it.

Guest: The performances these past two days have been truly sublime. Honestly, I've never experienced concerts of this caliber anywhere else.

Guest: Here's my form.

Cruise Ticket Seller: There's only a single word here. Are you sure about this, signore?

Guest: The cruise is about to end. I must seize this opportunity.

Guest: This brilliant musicista ... One can only witness her talent aboard the "Free Breeze."

Guest: Is it really as they say that there is no music Barcarola cannot play?

Guest: If so, what I wrote there should not be a demanding request—merely broad in scope.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Of course, signore. It is simply my job to confirm these things.

The ticket seller places the form atop a stack of papers with a diligent smile.

Cruise Ticket Seller: On every voyage, we encounter five or six curious passengers like yourself, signore.

Cruise Ticket Seller: But perhaps you should have written a few a little more, then you'd pose a real challenge for her, sì?

Guest: Well, I'm not trying to make things difficult here. Aren't you curious to see which piece Signorina Barcarola will choose?

Guest: I'll listen closely what kind of melody she believes will fit my hometown.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Then we must hurry, signore. Let's find you a seat up front.

Guest: Yes, I was a few minutes late yesterday and almost couldn't get in.

Guest: I really hope she'll come ashore to perform in a concert hall someday. Tickets for the "Free Breeze" are getting harder to come by.

Atrium, "Free Breeze" Cruise Ship

Excited Passenger: How much longer? I've been waiting all day!

Excited Passenger: Will she begin with "Morning Mood" or "Symphonie Fantastique"? Or perhaps "Boléro"! The weather tonight is just perfect for it!

Crew Member I: Or perhaps our musical genius will delight us with a little improvisation!

Guest: Haha, it seems her audience remains as passionate as ever.

Guest: But it is as I said, I can only imagine how popular Signorina Barcarola would be if she performed on land.

Cruise Ticket Seller: You will have to keep wondering. She prefers life on this ship. Perhaps she just enjoys the opportunity to travel.

Cruise Ticket Seller: It might be that more would come to see her on land, but she is not one to be so tied down.

Crew Member II: Good evening, signori!

Crew Member II: Please take a seat right here. If you've come to applaud our beloved star, I'd be happy to sort out two "special seats" for you.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Come on, you really think a well-dressed fellow like him would want to sit on an old barrel with us?

Cruise Ticket Seller: We're only sitting here so we can stay close by—to keep an eye on things, just in case ...

The dignified gentleman joins them on the barrel, turning his eyes toward the stage with intense focus.

Guest: The honor is mine.

Cruise Ticket Seller: It seems you're in for a truly novel experience tonight.

Guest: I intend to fully enjoy it before my time on the cruise ends.

Guest: I made sure I was first in line for the song requests, hours ahead of the concert, and now here I am—the closest spot in the house.

Guest: But for Signorina Barcarola, it is worth every effort.

Crew Member II: Shh! I can see it! That's her Crackling Box.

How do you spot a musician in a crowd?

Where Barcarola is concerned, the first thing that catches anyone's eye is her remarkable instrument.

Barcarola: Welcome, welcome! Ladies and gentlemen, guests of the "Free Breeze," benvenuti! I welcome you aboard and thank you for joining us on our journey!

Barcarola: As the ship's musical conductor, I will be performing tonight's concert for you.

An unusual instrument flashes from the cabin door.

Riding atop a sea of applause and cheers, the petite girl takes the steps up to the stage with an air of musical grace.

Barcarola: As always, I've received all of your song requests.

Barcarola: Tonight's performance will follow the sequence of your requests. However, I regret that I must once again affirm my rule that I will not be playing any piece twice during the entirety of this voyage.

Barcarola: As our musical director, I must ensure that each of you is able to embrace the true diversity of music and sound.

Cruise Ticket Seller: I wonder what she will do. Does she have a tune already in mind, or maybe she'll improvise something new?

Guest: Shh! Quiet, quiet!

The man gestures for the crew to be quiet, straightening up as if a king seated on his barrel throne.

The whole stack of request forms is displayed before Barcarola, before she retracts them close to her.

Guest: Good heavens, I've never been this nervous.

She picks up the first form, reading the handwriting with a careful and considered scan.

Then she folds it.

Guest: I'm ready. This is sure to be a phenomenal experience.

She holds the paper, and then proceeds to leaf it back into the stack.

Before lifting up the next form.

Guest: What?!

Crew Member II: Perhaps you requested a piece that has already been performed?

Guest: No, no, impossible! I—

Guest: All I wrote was a word, a place ... I had hoped that Signorina Barcarola would grace me with a melody that might remind me of it again!

The "king" is so shocked. He nearly falls from his barrel throne.

But the performance does not pause for him. The music and words continue to flow.

Barcarola: Okay, tonight's opening piece shall be Boléro.

Barcarola: Although we're lacking the space to give this piece a proper dance, I encourage everyone to join in and take a few steps!

Guest: I don't believe my ears!

Guest: How could a great musician such as her be bested by so trivial a request.

Guest: I must ask her. I need to know why she skipped my request.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Easy there, signore.

The crew members instinctively reach out in perfect sync, one to the left and one to the right, grasping at the guest as he rises from his seat.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Signorina Barcarola didn't throw away your request. She merely tucked it away.

Cruise Ticket Seller: You've already seen several performances. You must realize that this doesn't mean that she won't play it.

Crew Member II: Congratulations, signore. I believe this may mean you are in for a special delight!

Anytime our Barcarola breaks from the norm, it can only be a sign of some particular stroke of genius.

Their reassuring words have a silver-tongued sheen to them, coaxing the man's frustrations away.

Guest: ... Fine.

But, before the man can retake his throne, he turns to see a child has usurped him. The dethroned king leans against the wall, sulking.

And his two courtiers follow closely in his wake.

Cruise Ticket Seller: We've been working alongside Signorina Barcarola for a while now. We're very familiar with her methods.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Please, signore, wait. A little patience, and I assure you: you will have your satisfaction.

Crew Member II: In her two years performing for the "Free Breeze," we've never received a single complaint or negative review!

Light footsteps approach, and a voice joins the conversation at just the right moment.

Cruise Ship Musician: Has she really been aboard the ship for that long now?

Cruise Ticket Seller: It doesn't seem so long ago, does it? When she first came aboard, she had only wanted to observe and help out with the maintenance while we were at port.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Whenever we returned, and we returned frequently. She was always there waiting for us, until she joined us officially.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Everyone has chipped in at some point to help her scrape together some musical gear, cassette tapes, or various little gadgets.

The rising sound of music begins to overtake their conversation in the corner of the hall.

The ticket seller acknowledges the new participant in their conversation.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Oh, you received a gift from her too, didn't you?

Cruise Ticket Seller: I imagine that cassette is still tucked under your pillow.

Cruise Ship Musician: Oh, yes.

Cruise Ship Musician: A record of a treasured memory.

Guest: Please, if I might ask—why did she decide to join the "Free Breeze"?

Guest: I mean no disrespect. Only that, with her rare talent, it seems almost a waste that she be confined to just a single ship.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Perhaps the only reason is that we were the first to invite her.

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COL-310802

Promised Destinations

Inland Port, Cremona

Cruise Ticket Seller: Do you really mean that you won't join the "Free Breeze" Band, Signorina? If you were to join, I know the captain would be over the moon!

Cruise Ticket Seller: When we played him the song we recorded last time, he borrowed the tape on the spot and still hasn't given it back!

Cruise Ship Musician: Oh yes, please, Barcarola! Aren't you always talking about how much fun it would be to travel the world on a big ship?

Cruise Ship Musician: I'll tell you right now, I'd much rather have you join us than some random musician off the street!

More and more fervent invitations leap up to overwhelm the young girl sitting on the ground.

Barcarola: Hmm ... I'm thinking ...

Barcarola: Something's still missing. Oh! It's here!

Barcarola: Astrictus!

The subtle friction of the device's components forms a harmonious melody.

As if accomplishing some momentous feat, the little girl rises with a beaming smile and announces loudly—

Barcarola: It's fixed! The reeds inside the melodica were a bit loose, but I glued them up nice and securely!

Barcarola: Here you go. I think that I overcomplicated things at the start. I hope you didn't mind the wait ... scusa.

Cruise Ticket Seller: What does ten minutes matter? We're not setting sail until tomorrow anyway. This is downtime for us, and we can spend it however we want.

Cruise Ticket Seller: But, you did fix up the melodica up properly, no?

Barcarola: Certo, I'd say it's set for a hundred years now! Maybe you can pass it down to your children as a family heirloom!

Barcarola: Nothing else needs repairing, does it?

Cruise Ticket Seller: No, no, nothing at all. We thought about going around breaking everything on the ship just to keep you around, but if the captain caught us, he'd have us swimming with the fishes.

Cruise Ship Musician: Don't exaggerate. The captain is a kind man. Barcarola, don't listen to his nonsense.

Cruise Ship Musician: Will you accept that invitation? I really do hope that you'll join us!

Barcarola: I know—we could count the fishtails splashing out of the ocean together, listen to new songs in different ports, and earn the applause of passengers from everywhere in the world.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Not to mention sampling the specialties of each and every taverna along the way.

Cruise Ship Musician: We'll busk on the streets when the ship's docked to earn a little extra cash.

Cruise Ship Musician: We can come along to help you find new instruments! No more waiting around for us to come back.

Barcarola: But the "Free Breeze" sails so far away.

Barcarola: I worry for my parents. How would they feel if I was so far away where not even a postcard or phone call could reach me?

Silence.

Time after time, their invitations fell away to silence.

Barcarola: But maybe things will change. I haven't even finished my final exam! When I get first place, I'll be sure to let all of you know!

Cruise Ship Musician: Will you remember to tell me first?

Barcarola: Of course! You have the word of Cremona's number one up-and-coming music star!

Barcarola: I swear, after I pass the exam, I'll quickly gather my things, dash off to the port, and hop onto the "Free Breeze," just like—*click*

Cruise Ticket Seller: Hah! More like "boom"! When you finally do come aboard, the weight of your luggage might just sink us all!

Barcarola: Oh, no special treatment for aspiring virtuosos?

Barcarola: If you're worried my collection isn't compact enough, I'm close to solving that problem too.

Barcarola: Whether it's the violin, saxophone, piano, or melodica—anything other instruments can do, my new invention will do it better.

Barcarola: My Crackling Box is going to shake the world of music to its roots!

Barcarola: First things first. I believe you have a little something I requested.

Barcarola: Now hand it over!

She extends an open expectant hand to her friends, her eyes gleaming.

Cruise Ship Musician: I chose the one with the most beautiful tone, just for you.

Barcarola: A clarinet. Hmm ... the maestro of the ensemble, extremely popular. Wide application, with adaptable tone changes.

Barcarola: Grazie mille! The timing is perfect. I will incorporate it into my Crackling Box!

She grabs the clarinet and, with her other hand, offers a cassette tape.

Barcarola: All my best pieces I've come up with recently are all on here. Some are practice sessions, and a few melodies I composed myself.

Barcarola: Oh, and the sounds of footsteps on cobblestone streets, doves fluttering their wings, the waves on the river on a windy day, the sound of wood being polished in the bottega ...

Barcarola: This is the "essence" of Cremona. I even climbed the bell tower to record the breeze sweeping by from above.

Cruise Ship Musician: I'm almost done with mine. One thing I can tell you in advance—I recorded an especially unique performance on the streets of Sydney.

Vinyl records are slowly being phased out, and CDs are only now gaining popularity. This is the heyday for cassette tapes.

They can carry many things—a speech, pre-recorded music programs, sounds from around the world.

Some even faithfully record the heartbeat of a city, becoming gifts for cherished friends.

Cruise Ship Musician: Next time, no, the time after that, which place would you like to hear next?

Barcarola: Melbourne or Perth, Brisbane, Fremantle ...

Barcarola: I can contrast their sounds and try to add their unique characteristics into my songs.

The friend accepts the gift, placing it into her pocket.

Cruise Ship Musician: Alright, next time, I'll bring you two tapes—Sydney and Brisbane.

Barcarola: Deal! You must make it back in time. If I get them before the exam, I should have time to prepare.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Rest assured. The captain is familiar with this route. There won't be any mishaps. Don't worry.

Cruise Ticket Seller: As for that exam, what was it again? Making a violin by hand and then performing on the spot—shouldn't that be a walk in the park for you?

Barcarola: It's not as easy for me as you think. Even though I've been putting most of my time into preparing for it.

Barcarola: I plan to perform my own music.

Cruise Ship Musician: You mean like the practice pieces on your tape?

Barcarola: It should be even more beautiful than them. I've been layering sounds from different instruments and places all around Cremona, arranging them meticulously into a complete composition.

Barcarola: Violin and clarinet, French horn and timpani, saxophone, harp, even oud, tin whistle, pan flute ...

Barcarola: The Crackling Box will be able to emulate the timbre of each and every instrument in the world!

A bold and steadfast vow.

Barcarola: There are pieces suitable for recording and others for live performance. Just as the music played in the piazza is quite different from what one plays in a church.

Barcarola: Some sounds are more beautiful when heard in specific environments, and some are hard to reproduce even with the finest instruments.

Barcarola: My dreams are larger than just playing the violin.

The words come out rehearsed, and they have been many times; still, they are not ready to be heard by the audience that matters.

On the grass by the river, though, her true wishes flow out more easily.

Cruise Ship Musician: Then you absolutely, positively have to join us on the "Free Breeze"!

Cruise Ticket Seller: With this invention of yours, you'll be an entire one-woman orchestra. Tickets will sell like gelato on a hot day!

Cruise Ticket Seller: Forget about being in the band. We might just make you captain!

Barcarola: Then my first order of business as capitano shall be to turn the ship into a maritime concert hall, and we'll return only three times per year—make that twice!

Barcarola: But before that, I need to pass my exam.

Barcarola: Until next time. I have to rush home before rehearsal ends so that I can lie in my room pretending to have a stomach ache.

Cruise Ticket Seller: As you wish, capitano!

Cruise Ship Musician: You'll do great, Barcarola!

The young musician runs off but doesn't forget to wave a heartfelt goodbye to her friends.

Barcarola's Home

Barcarola: Made it! Looks like no one's back yet.

Barcarola: Perfect! My new recording's theme will be "A Day in Cremona."

Barcarola: After all, they're always saying they appreciate a little soothing music from home to help them sleep while at sea.

The tune she plays is a familiar lullaby. According to her mother, everyone in the family has hummed its gentle melody to her at some point.

Barcarola's day used to begin with it.

She sets the instrument, now both a violin and clarinet together, in her hands and sits at the window, looking out down the river to the sea that lies far beyond the horizon.

She breathes deeply, allowing the air to flow evenly and smoothly from her chest.

Barcarola: On the sea glitters the silver star.

Barcarola: Gentle the waves, favorable the winds.

One more time.

Barcarola: On the sea glitters the silver star ...

One more time?

Barcarola: Forget it. "Repeated failure leads to success" is too easy a trap to fall into.

Barcarola: Somehow, it never sounds as good as when I was little.

Barcarola: Perhaps the timbre has changed. Just as violins made from wood with different grains sound different.

Barcarola: Or maybe it's because my environment has changed. Where did I use to sing this song?

She slides her hand up fluidly from the wooden cabinet's edge to rest against her forehead.

The corners of the furniture bear splashes of paint marks. Back then, she had to raise her left hand high and stretch out the brush to reach it. Now, she has to squat down to see her graffiti clearly.

Barcarola: Varnishing violins is an art. How could a child possibly understand it?

Barcarola: And naming things. Sigh, in the future, when they introduce me, they'll have to say, "This is the great musician Barcarola, and her treasured instrument, the Crackling Box."

Today is the same as countless other afternoons in the past.

Another lonely afternoon spent with her Crackling Box.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310803

A Monotonous Rondo

Barcarola's Home

Barcarola's Mother: Thank you all for taking the time to visit us.

Barcarola's Mother: The violins used in this demonstration are merely samples. Next month, we will hold a formal concert with them.

Barcarola's Mother: If you have any questions or suggestions, please feel free to share.

Barcarola's Mother: A violin that fits its player's habits is the best violin.

Merchants, musicians, collectors, and a few curious researchers.

This house never lacks for enthusiastic visitors.

Barcarola's Mother: Oh, Federico is really very busy. The bottega always keeps him tied up.

Barcarola's Mother: If you want to order a violin, you'll need to discuss it with him. We have several excellent apprentices, but if you insist on having him make it personally, I'm afraid you'll have to wait some time.

Barcarola's Mother: I don't know when exactly. He's been eating and sleeping at the bottega these past few weeks. He's only been back once and even then just to grab something.

The hostess smoothly handles the flurry of questions.

In a corner of the room, a small figure holds her breath, waiting for her moment.

Barcarola: I'm about to nod off before the performance even begins.

Barcarola: My parents never took my Crackling Box seriously. They always say my friends are only humoring me when they say they like it.

Barcarola: This time, we'll see how complete strangers react, and I'll know for sure.

Curled up in the cabinet, the girl holds her instrument tightly, careful not to let it get knocked around.

Barcarola's Mother: Yes, an Amati-style violino delivers a mellower, more classical, and pure sound—like the sound of spring water.

Barcarola's Mother: But if you prefer a brighter sound, the next performance should satisfy you.

Barcarola's Mother: Stradivari violins have never failed their reputation in this regard.

Several apprentices have already positioned violins on their shoulders.

As soon as the hostess finishes speaking, a harmonious melody follows.

Collector: Bravo, bravo. In the music hall, I'm certain the sound quality will come through even more clearly.

Collector: That inclined neck is a stunning work of craftsmanship.

Merchant: Haha. I happen to have an order from an orchestra here. I know it will be a wait, but for this quality, even a year will be worth it.

Taking advantage of the quiet conversation, new notes quietly diffuse into the air.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310804

Collector: Oh, how novel! Besides violins, we will indeed need other timbres as a complement.

Musician: Of course, amici! Young children need such diversions to cultivate their musical sense.

Collector: Hahahaha, who hasn't been there?

The music ends, followed by sustained, enthusiastic applause.

The hostess also offers a few begrudged words of praise.

Merchant: It appears this little surprise was arranged specially for us all. Now I'll really have to grit my teeth and order a few more violins.

Merchant: If possible, perhaps you would introduce us to our elusive performer?

Barcarola's Mother: My apologies. Troubling this particular performer might be quite overwhelming. Our giovane has a touch of stage fright.

Barcarola's Mother: But I believe you'll meet at next month's concert, signore.

Musician: A giovane! I'll be sure to arrive on time then, signora.

The small audience's discussion eventually fades into the distance.

A hand raised in the dark gently falls on the Crackling Box.

Barcarola: I knew it. They adore you!

Barcarola: But this isn't some practice toy for bambinos! Hmm, perhaps because it was too sudden and unexpected. I'll need to prepare more.

Barcarola: Just—

Rapid footsteps draw near.

Barcarola's Mother: Come out now, Barcarola.

Barcarola's Mother: Like a thief in the night. Have all the good manners we taught you gone out the window?

Barcarola: *gasp*

Barcarola's Mother: Skipping practice, wasting time down at the river, and let us not mention that bow you made at the bottega—thoroughly unacceptable.

Barcarola's Mother: What good do all your gifts and intelligence do if they're so poorly utilized? Aren't there enough mad geniuses in the family already?

Barcarola: That bow was custom-built! I made it for my instrument ...

Barcarola's Mother: Come on out now! No more excuses.

Barcarola: Wait! Mamma!

Barcarola: Astrictus ...!

At this critical moment, her Astrictus heartlessly forsakes her.

Another minor blunder in her countless failed attempts.

Her mother's hand grasps her wrist, pulling her and the Crackling Box out together.

Barcarola: Alright, mi dispiace, Mamma ...

Barcarola: But they loved my performance! I heard their applause!

Barcarola: They really praised it! It wasn't just to humor me. Didn't you hear them?

Barcarola: ...

Barcarola: I just don't want to only play the violin.

An inconvenient confession.

Barcarola's Mother: Let me see your instrument.

Barcarola's Mother: Why the hesitation? Always trust your own craftsmanship. Have you forgotten that too?

This instrument is visibly different from every other violin, viola and cello in their workshop. In fact, it's barely recognizable as a violin at all.

Its proportions are out of place and oddly shaped. The violin's neck is itself formed from what appears to be a clarinet.

Barcarola's Mother: ...

Barcarola's Mother: Your father and I selected the best spruce and maple for your violin. It's not easy to find wood with such tight and even growth rings.

Barcarola's Mother: I prepared the best varnish I've ever mixed for this.

Barcarola's Mother: We wanted to give you the most special gift we could—one that fits you best, an instrument you would love most of all.

Barcarola's Mother: Do you like it?

Barcarola: Yes, Mamma. It has a name. It's my beloved Crackling Box.

Barcarola's Mother: Despite these embellishments, you've done well for someone your age.

Barcarola's Mother: Take it.

Her mother's actions surprise her. The explanations she had prepared all slip away.

Ultimately, she can only inquire softly—

Barcarola: You're not angry, Mamma?

Barcarola: Then you've finally embraced my idea? I'm so happy!

Barcarola's Mother: I'm not mad at you, Barcarola.

Her mother's words are gentle but coiled.

Barcarola's Mother: I'm just disappointed. I once believed you were talented enough to take over the family bottega or become a great musician in your own right.

Barcarola's Mother: But who would ever take this Crackling Box of yours seriously? Who would buy such an instrument, and who in the world would ever wish to listen to it?

Barcarola's Mother: For all that talent, do you really think that the people of Cremona will ever recognize you with this? That you can pass your exam with it?

Barcarola's Mother: Without the Stradivari name behind you, would anyone applaud?

Even in her mother's dulcet calm voice, the questions sink deep, and the smile disappears from Barcarola's face.

Barcarola: No. I don't perform for their applause!

Barcarola: All you care about is the violin. Is there really nothing else, no room for anything more?

Barcarola: The violin botteghe aren't doing as well as they used to, Mamma. We have fewer and fewer workshops every year. Haven't you noticed?

Barcarola: Why can't we make changes that go beyond adjusting shapes, wood, and varnish formulas?

Barcarola: Must we continue like this until we're completely left behind by the rest of the world?

She fires back with a barrage of questions, stepping back from her mother with each one until she's almost left the room.

This marks her second failure of the day.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310805

Church, Cremona

The city is dotted with many churches, and their unattended pews at times serve as sanctuaries for those seeking a place of solitude.

Amid the bustling streets of Cremona, there is one such pew in one such church—a small quiet spot that belongs to Barcarola alone.

Barcarola: I've already recorded the reverberations inside the church. Ah, if only there were an organ here ...

Barcarola: The percussion might be unclear, though. Perhaps playing legato would be best.

Barcarola: That's enough for today. I must find some time to visit the cathedral. With the differences in architecture and space, it's sure to have a unique acoustic quality.

The girl puts away the cassette tape and leans on a pew to observe her surroundings.

The stained glass reflects the sunlight in a dazzling array. When she was younger, she would run around catching those rays.

This empty church has kept many of her secrets, its saints the first audience to her compositions.

It never opposed her vows and wishes, no matter how absurd they might sound, it gave her no confusion or doubt, it never responded at all.

Barcarola: I shouldn't have told Mamma the world would leave her behind, should I?

Barcarola: She and Papà have to make violins, manage the bottega. They basically have to let the teachers take care of me most days. They certainly don't have time to travel.

Barcarola: Did I mess up again?

There are always exhibitions taking place at home, one after the other.

Anxious to prove herself, the child doesn't overlook this fact.

She still lets the Crackling Box perform its melodies in them, she still earns the crowd's applause, and she is still prepared to be reprimanded by her parents.

But things are different now.

Barcarola's Mother: You are right. We have indeed made some improvements to the traditional violin body.

Barcarola's Mother: Such contours allow them to perform better in large concert halls.

Barcarola's Mother: Yes, we test them many times to come as close to perfection as possible. The next exhibition is looking forward to your attendance.

After seeing off the guests, the hostess turns back to the room.

This time, without anyone pulling her out of the wardrobe, the girl stands steadily on her own two feet.

Barcarola's Mother: What's wrong? Stellina.

Barcarola's Mother: Is there a problem with your classes?

Barcarola: No, Maestro Battista said I've made great progress with my vibrato technique.

Barcarola: Mamma, I have something to ask you.

Her mother's calm demeanor leaves her at a loss, forcing her to stammer through an explanation.

Barcarola: Maestro Battista said that music transcends race and status.

Barcarola: "It is another language that allows people to explore unknown worlds."

Barcarola: "Whoever you are, and wherever you go, it will always stir the depths of your soul."

Barcarola: "As performers, we must fully comprehend the role we play. It is our duty to channel the emotions of music to the world."

Barcarola: I think the violin is great, but it can't express all my thoughts.

Barcarola: And in its current state, neither can my Crackling Box.

Barcarola: Violins can mimic human voices, but I want to find instruments that can imitate flowing water or the sound of fruit falling from trees.

Barcarola: I want to make the Crackling Box able to convey every sound in the world.

Barcarola: Do you think I'll succeed, Mamma?

Cruise Ship Musician: Did you manage to persuade your mother?

Cruise Ship Musician: Wonderful, Barcarola! We're just about to set off!

Barcarola: It's like you're about to set off on a pirate adventure or something.

Barcarola: Anyway, this is for you.

Barcarola: I know you wanted to listen to it, but I feel that the singing parts alone won't be enough to help you sleep!

Barcarola: So, I did a bit of research on the arrangement of lullabies.

Barcarola: And I seized the opportunity to test the Crackling Box—nothing major, though.

Barcarola: This one is called "A Day in Cremona." I went to the church yesterday specifically to record some quieter sounds.

As the girl introduces her new achievements, she finds herself unconsciously adopting a familiar tone.

Just like a certain luthier proudly displaying the beautiful violins in her family workshop.

Cruise Ship Musician: I knew you'd have a surprise up your sleeve!

Cruise Ship Musician: And this is for you—two cassettes, just like you asked for.

Cruise Ship Musician: I even met a guy from France with a Breton drum. It's got a really cool sound. I recorded a segment for you, right at the end of the tape.

Their gift swap comes to an end, and the girls move on to discuss their lives.

Barcarola: So, how's the "Free Breeze" been lately? You came back so quickly!

Barcarola: Was there some bad weather? No trouble this time, right?

Cruise Ship Musician: Apparently, the captain had some personal matters to deal with. He didn't really explain it to us.

Cruise Ship Musician: But we do have some big news. Notice how Brian didn't come back with us this time? He disembarked at a different port. We'll pick him up on the return trip.

Cruise Ship Musician: Every family has its skeletons.

Barcarola: Do you ever get homesick? I mean, even if you're used to life on the ship, do you ever wish you could stay on land for a little longer?

Barcarola: Right now, I just feel like Cremona is stuck in a big violin case, trapping all other sounds inside.

Cruise Ship Musician: Once you leave home, the novelty wears off quick, and you'll eventually start to miss that solid, grounded feeling of standing on terra firma.

Cruise Ship Musician: The captain told us he's planning on running the ship for another five or six years, then handing it over to someone else.

Cruise Ship Musician: You know, make enough money, find a place he likes, and settle down, so he doesn't have to keep running around when he's older.

Cruise Ship Musician: But what about you, Barcarola? We know your dreams are bigger than this one town.

At the sound of her friend's concern, Barcarola falls silent for a moment.

If she leaves Cremona, will everything change?

And if she were to leave the violin behind, will she find the freedom to express herself?

There are countless cities and instruments in the world. Cremona is just one small place in Italy, and Italy is just a small slice of the world.

She knows this land. She knows the bricks and mortar of it, the seasons as they change, and how it is sung about in folk songs.

Barcarola: I ...

Barcarola's Mother: I see what you're thinking, and I understand.

Barcarola's Mother: But you will not forget about your exam date. Remember your priorities.

Barcarola's Mother: Children go through all kinds of hobbies and odd ideas. Ever since you were little, you've had such an imaginative mind.

Barcarola's Mother: Your Astrictus has always been unpredictable, maybe because you think too much.

Barcarola's Mother: Imagination should be a good fit for the Astrictus, though. This arcane skill only works if you can picture in your mind what the materials should look like once they're joined.

Barcarola's Mother: You're as fickle as the weather.

Barcarola's Mother: Maybe you'll give up on this idea too.

Barcarola: ...

Barcarola: No, we already talked about this.

Barcarola: I'm leaving Cremona. Once I pass my exams, I'm boarding the "Free Breeze" and leaving this place.

Barcarola: When that time comes, I'll sing a song that I could never record for you.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310806

Practice Room

The modest venue is packed with people all around, leaving only the central area free for the performers.

Among them, a young girl draws the most attention.

Barcarola: Phew ... relax ...

Barcarola: After today, I'll pack up my things and start counting the days until the ship comes back.

Barcarola: Fingering, sheet music, posture ... nothing can go wrong.

Barcarola: My instrument, nessun problema. My Crackling Box is in better shape than ever.

The eyes of the crowd make her instrument feel somewhat heavier.

But she's grown used to being watched. She straightens her back and steadies the instrument on her shoulder.

Barcarola: My parents, and Maestro Battista, I just know they're going to be amazed by my new piece.

Barcarola: This song carries the scent of the sea breeze, just like a journey across the ocean to the faraway ports of Australia.

Barcarola: If we cannot travel, then at least I can bring the sounds from these distant places here.

Apprentice: Next we have—Signora Barcarola!

Apprentice: Our youngest little musician, the pride of the Stradivari!

Apprentice: I won't repeat the accomplishments she's made on her path to mastering the violin here. Remember, her playing once even made the fish in the River Po leap to shore.

Barcarola: Mamma mia! That was just a misunderstanding! And something of an exaggeration. It was about to rain that day, and ...

Apprentice: Let's see if Signora Barcarola can take the top spot this year!

Apprentice: Please come forward and show us your violin. Let us admire its elegant neck, its gleaming surface, the pinnacle of craftsmanship from the legendary ...

Apprentice: Is that really what you're playing with?

Barcarola: Yes, this is my instrument.

This time, she doesn't hesitate, naturally holding her Crackling Box in her hands and raising it so that everyone, even in the farthest corners, can see it.

The crowd falls into an odd silence.

Barcarola: The wood chosen by my parents is the best there is. Its sound is rich and balanced.

Barcarola: The varnish, the strings, the edges, the curvature of the body—these took quite some time to perfect.

Most children taking the exam will follow their family's example and remake a violin from scratch.

The other option is nearly impossible. But making small improvements to an existing instrument can be even more difficult than crafting a new instrument from nothing.

Barcarola: No matter the standard, it's already perfect enough.

Barcarola: The best instrument is the one that truly suits the performer.

Barcarola: I didn't want to make just another beautiful copy, and I love my violin. It has always been with me.

Barcarola: But, I've made a few modifications to make it more suited to my style.

Barcarola: It's not yet finished, and I'll continue trying to combine new instruments with it until it is.

Barcarola: For now, though, I intend to perform a brand-new piece for you.

Amid the stunned silence, she raises her bow.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310807

Musician: How refreshing! I've never heard music like this, and I've certainly never seen a violin like that.

Collector: Our mischievous little ragazza has brought her precious toy to the stage. Quite adorable, don't you think?

Collector: Signor Cristiano, I'm certain you wouldn't have had the courage to do something like this at her age.

Musician: Hahaha, when she grows up, she'll surely be an even better violinist than I am!

After a moment, new sounds fill the room.

Applause breaks out, polite and measured.

From their courteous smiles, she can already read the results of her exam.

Barcarola: Juvenile, impractical, unsuitable ...

Barcarola: They'll never take my Crackling Box seriously.

Barcarola: All they can think of is their traditions that no one would ever want to buy an instrument like this.

Barcarola: Is that all we can strive for as artisans—to sell as many of our instruments as we can?

Barcarola: I don't belong here, not in this "City of Violins," not when there's no room for anything else.

The young girl curls up on her familiar pew, fiddling with her exam results, her mind somewhere else.

After folding it several times, it becomes a neat little paper airplane.

Barcarola: Your rustling sounds are actually quite interesting, but ...

Barcarola: How can a piece of paper summarize my entire life so completely?

Barcarola: I'm leaving Cremona, and you're going to stay here in some corner, forgotten.

Barcarola: Three, two, one. Yah!

The paper airplane glides smoothly out of the church doors, disappearing from Barcarola's sight.

Along with it, the "unsatisfactory" results and her hesitation vanish.

She stands up, the light from the stained glass blurring her vision for a moment, but she quickly steadies herself.

Barcarola: Maybe I'll come back, maybe I won't.

Barcarola: But first, I must spend some time away. Maybe the next time we come back to port, I'll visit.

Barcarola: And it'll still be the "City of Violins," and the Stradivari will still be the greatest of their violin makers.

Barcarola: Will they miss me? What will they say about me—the girl who doesn't quite belong?

Her hand traces the old pew, feeling the deep grooves in the wood.

Barcarola: No one will be there to cast incantations for your small repairs; no one will wish to record your voice and turn it into a song.

Barcarola: Will you still be here? Will someone come and clean your pews and wipe your stained glass?

Barcarola: It's time to say a proper goodbye.

The church remains silent, save for the clacking of footsteps walking toward the door.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Really? You mean it? You've really decided to join the "Free Breeze"?

Cruise Ticket Seller: Oh, gosh! This is ...

Barcarola: I know it's abrupt, and maybe you didn't think I was being serious before.

Barcarola: But if the ship's still short of musicians, I'd like to join.

Cruise Ticket Seller: That's amazing! I bet the others you'd join. Looks like I can buy lunch for the next few stops.

Cruise Ticket Seller: I'll pay for you, too. No need to be shy. Call it a celebration of our newest musicista.

Barcarola: Let's not forget, I'm only saying I've decided I want to join you.

Barcarola: I haven't even spoken to the captain yet. What if I fail the audition?

Cruise Ship Musician: Something on your mind, Barcarola? Is something getting you down?

Cruise Ship Musician: Was it your exam?

Her friend could tell her mood was off from the moment the conversation began.

Cruise Ship Musician: It's just like you said, it doesn't prove anything. It's just a way for a violin maker to gain a bit of recognition.

Cruise Ship Musician: That recognition is what keeps them going until they can run their own bottega.

Cruise Ship Musician: But that was never your plan, was it? You don't need that kind of recognition.

Barcarola: My parents and my teachers think I need it.

Barcarola: They think I'm wasting my talent and that I'm not taking my gifts seriously enough.

She moves her hand away from the violin's neck.

The once odd and impractical shape has been smoothed into an elegant and beautiful violin.

Cruise Ticket Seller: You took it apart?

Cruise Ship Musician: What are you thinking, Barcarola?! You spent ages figuring out how to make your Crackling Box!

Barcarola: I tried to do it before, but I couldn't bring myself to disassemble it.

Barcarola: Now I understand that separating things stuck together with Astrictus is much harder than keeping them intact.

Barcarola: This is actually an older violin, one I tried to make into a Crackling Box a long time ago.

Barcarola: I was still set on inheriting the bottega at that time. I thought I was destined to become the next great violin maker in the Stradivari family—the next Antonio.

Barcarola: If I leave it with my parents, they might accept my decision, and maybe they won't be too mad.

Barcarola: I've proven I can do it. I just know now that I don't want to be what they wanted me to be.

Barcarola: I'll explain everything to them tomorrow.

Barcarola: But for now, I guess I just hope you'll cheer on my performance.

Barcarola: Let's go. I have the perfect song to impress the captain.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310808

Barcarola's Mother: I see you've already made up your mind.

Barcarola's Mother: Have you thought about what you're doing? What if something happens, we won't be there to help you? What if you get sick or hurt? You'll be so far away.

Barcarola: Mamma, I'll be very careful.

Barcarola: I'll write, and when the ship returns, I'll come back to Cremona again. I'll visit you.

Barcarola: We won't be apart for too long—maybe three or five months at a time, and time will fly by.

Barcarola: Hardly enough time to even build a violin.

Barcarola's Mother: Three or five months—that's time I won't know how you are and what you're doing, figlia mia.

Barcarola's Mother: I was still expecting you to back down, just like those other times before.

Barcarola's Mother: First, you said you wanted to take over the bottega. Then, you decided to become a musician. And now you're leaving Cremona to join a cruise band.

Barcarola's Mother: You wanted to use your Astrictus to build tiny houses, and then, the next day, you tore them apart and made them into windmills.

Barcarola's Mother: When it came to your first family performance, you kept changing the song right up until the very moment you went on stage.

Barcarola's Mother: You're as fickle as the weather. What if you get tired of the ship? What will you do then?

Barcarola's Mother: You won't be able to just walk away.

Barcarola: The "Free Breeze" changes its route all the time, and there are always new passengers coming aboard.

Barcarola: I'll see so many new things, and everyone will want to hear my new music. I won't quit that easily!

Barcarola: It's not like Cremona, where everything always stays the same, and where everyone's always telling me what I should do.

There is no more need for rehearsing her words. She simply speaks her mind without hesitation.

And she has decided on her farewell gift.

Barcarola: This is for you, and for Papà.

Barcarola: I once tried to make a violin just as good as the Crackling Box.

Barcarola: But I changed my mind along the way.

Barcarola: Back then, I thought I'd finish it one day and make it just as good, maybe even better.

Barcarola: It wasn't long after I started taking performance lessons. I was fascinated by the sheer number of sounds, and I began to think about how to blend them into my music.

Barcarola: That's what I really wanted to do, not what I thought I "should" do.

Barcarola: Even if my Astrictus kept failing, even if no one took my Crackling Box seriously.

Barcarola: I finished it because I wanted to prove to you that I did genuinely work hard through all those lessons.

Barcarola: Each time I performed with my Crackling Box in Cremona, people just saw me as a child playing with a toy.

Barcarola: No matter whether it was the instrument or the performance, the people here never really accepted me. They were always just waiting for me to grow up—to stop being childish, to get serious, and to return to the world of violins ... their world.

Barcarola: This isn't what I want.

Barcarola: I used to want to become a luthier, but now I know what I want to do. I want to play music for the people on that ship.

Performers must fully comprehend the role they play. It is their duty to channel the emotions of music to the world.

The ship Barcarola speaks of is a place where she aims to play her role and fulfill her "duty."

Barcarola's Mother: This ...

Barcarola's Mother: Its edge joints are a little rough, and the varnish is uneven.

Barcarola's Mother: And the neck is slightly straighter than the one we made for you. It won't sound as bright as your Crackling Box.

Barcarola's Mother: You still have a long way to go before you can call yourself a luthier.

Barcarola's Mother: But then, becoming a musicista should just about suit you for now.

Her mother sighs, but the underlying encouragement in her words is evident.

Barcarola's Mother: Go, then.

Barcarola's Mother: At least, our family name will open doors for you in any orchestra.

Barcarola's Mother: Or just tell them you're from Cremona and show them your instrument—they'll know.

Barcarola's Mother: I won't worry too much about how you'll make a living, but just tell us if you run into any problems, va bene?

Barcarola: No, Mamma.

Barcarola: I won't travel as just another performer from Cremona or even a Stradivari luthier.

Barcarola: Just "Barcarola."

Barcarola: Don't worry, with or without the family name, I'll find a way.

Barcarola: But I don't want to go as some famed musician traveling the world. I want to be just an ordinary girl leaving home for the first time.

Barcarola's Mother: ...

Barcarola's Mother: When does your ship leave?

Barcarola: In three days. The captain says we'll be heading to some new ports, and we'll pass Cremona again in a year or so.

Barcarola: ...

Barcarola: I have to go now, to the bottega. Papà has been so busy lately. It's better that I go to see him.

Barcarola: A year really does go by in the blink of an eye.

Parting is never easy, but when a new life is so close at hand, all it takes is a step forward.

The sadness will fade, overtaken by excitement for what's to come.

But the sound of her mother's voice will always tug her heart back.

Barcarola's Mother: Stellina, just a little longer.

Barcarola's Mother: There are still a few things I need to say.

Day is breaking as the newest crew member steps onto the deck.

Most of her luggage has been moved into the cabin already, but one last piece remains.

Placing the two instrument cases down, Barcarola takes a moment to take in her first real steps aboard.

Barcarola: Phew ... finally.

Barcarola: These are, after all, the things I couldn't leave behind.

Cruise Ship Musician: Though thankfully you won't need to lug them around all the time!

Cruise Ship Musician: Here, let me take these to your room. You can take a walk around the ship and get used to things. We leave at noon, so there's plenty of time.

Cruise Ship Musician: No need to thank me! I'm sure I'll be asking you to teach me some techniques soon enough!

Her friend rushes off so quickly, she doesn't have a moment to reply.

She pushes open the nearest door.

The bustling scene before her is unlike anything she has seen before.

Music and voices fill the air, drowning out both the wind outside and the rocking of the ship.

Warm light streams down from above, reminding her of the light that shone through the church's stained-glass windows.

It is only now that she realizes she has left that world behind.

The church, the workshop, and the bell tower are all in the past now.

Barcarola: There are so many passengers.

Barcarola: I won't have to worry about not having an audience anymore.

Barcarola: I'm glad it wasn't all in vain. Those two violin cases are quite heavy.

Her mother's advice echoes in her ears.

Barcarola's Mother: Take this violin with you too.

Barcarola's Mother: There are pieces that only shine when played with the right instrument.

Barcarola's Mother: Maybe the right piece for it is still out there waiting for you.

Barcarola's Mother: If you find that piece, you can let me know when you come home to Cremona, va bene?

Barcarola's Mother: It's been a long time since you've played it.

Barcarola's Mother: But even so, it makes your Papà and I so happy to see how much you love your Crackling Box.

Barcarola's Mother: Keep exploring. The best instrument will be the one that suits you best.

What was once a proud declaration has now become a tender form of encouragement.

She repeats the words she shared at the time of her exam.

Barcarola's Mother: Good luck, Stellina.

Crew Member II: Let's say goodbye now, Mamma. The ship is about to set sail.

Mother: My child, I'm going to miss you. Let me hold you one more time, my child.

Crew Member II: Mamma, don't be like that. I'll be back before you know it.

The "Free Breeze" is scheduled to embark at noon. All those departing aboard it exchange their final goodbyes.

Barcarola: Mamma mia! I—I forgot to give them a hug!

Barcarola: And I didn't say goodbye to Maestro Battista either. I haven't even seen him since the exam!

Barcarola: And there's still so many sounds left in Cremona.

Suddenly, all those unrecorded sounds grow unbearably loud, like rolling thunder in a storm.

The noise rushes over her, leaving her feeling suffocated and alone.

Farewells can feel so cold, like iron and rain, like a violin string drawn taut and silent.

Barcarola: ...

Barcarola: No, this can't be happening.

In a panic, she turns around and dashes out through the door.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310809

Mamma, me and you.

Barcarola: ...!

Barcarola: There's still time.

She steps over the threshold, walks out onto the deck, and descends the gangplank.

Turning back, she gazes at the place she is leaving behind.

We sit in a dark corner.

Take another good look at this city.

Its crowded squares and its ancient alleys, all so full of music.

Its gentle breath before dawn, its heartbeat resonating in the air, pulsing with the crowd.

Barcarola: Mamma ... Papà ...

Barcarola: There are seeds sprouting on my windowsill.

I wish I could share with you the story of a bird returning to its roost.

Barcarola's Mother: ...

The hostess sits at the table and turns on a machine.

The tape begins to play, faithfully recounting all it has recorded.

Barcarola: This is your Stellina's farewell message.

Barcarola: I know I won't be gone for long, but I already feel homesick.

Barcarola: Papà and Mamma are busy at work, and it's really not my style to express these sentiments.

Barcarola: So, I'll let this cassette tape—one of the greatest inventions in history—do the talking.

Like a quiet, drawn-out melody.

Barcarola: The sounds from within and outside of Cremona are all recorded on it.

Barcarola: You can listen to them when you have the time.

Barcarola: I love you.

Like a soft and endless melody. Like my dearest, oldest friend.

Street, Cremona

The old town seems so empty in the early dawn. All is silent and still.

When it is so silent, the clatter off cobblestones ring out especially loud.

Barcarola: Not far now.

Barcarola: Just two more alleys to go.

For a brief moment, she wishes she could take back every decision she'd made up till this point.

Let time move to that distant, sunny afternoon.

The first time she tried mixing varnish for a violin, she used it to paint the wooden cabinet.

Back to a childhood where no road led forward.

Like a weary bird returning to its nest just as life's journey now beckons me onward.

Her pace leaves her breathless.

Or perhaps it's the thought of arriving at her destination that makes her hesitate.

Is this yet another choice she will ultimately abandon?

Will she really turn her back on the "Free Breeze"?

Barcarola: The ship doesn't leave until noon. I can still go back, pack, and explain everything to the captain and my friends.

Barcarola: There's still time. If I'm quick, I'll be home in time for breakfast.

Barcarola: Homemade jam and sausages ... fresh bread with golden crust ...

Barcarola: ...

She dabs her tear-filled eyes with her sleeve.

The morning light passes over her, but she still can't bring herself to make a choice.

My place isn't here in Cremona. I must journey into the vast unknown.

Piazza, Cremona

Even in the dawn, the piazza is as lively as ever, each corner claimed by merchants, visitors, and townsfolk.

Same as it ever was—it's just another day.

Barcarola: Cremona ...

Barcarola: The same old street musicians are still here, playing the same old songs.

She moves closer, unable to resist, and one of the girls recognizes her.

Street Artist: Barcarola! The genius violinist with her head in the clouds!

Street Artist: Where are you off to now? Another performance, or are you working on something with your father?

Street Artist: Care to play a song? Come on, it's been ages.

The girl affectionately drapes her arm over Barcarola's shoulder and hands her the violin.

She leans in and lowers her voice.

Street Artist: Lend me a hand, will you? For old times' sake. Use your name to back me up here. Remember all the times we played together when we were kids?

Street Artist: Look how busy the street is. It's the perfect time to pull in a crowd.

Street Artist: Hey—Isn't that one of the Stradivaris?

Street Artist: She's come down here just to play for us!

With all the commotion, many eyes had been drawn their way.

But that famous name being roared aloud is enough to spur them into motion, gathering around.

Barcarola: I'll play just one piece.

Barcarola: Though I'm kind of busy right now, so ... va bene, I'll get started.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310810

The applause is exactly as she anticipated.

Tourist: Lucky me! I've been in Cremona for days now, but this is the first time I've seen a show like this!

Hawker: Too right, signore, too right. And why not take this chance to pick up an instrument just as amazing as hers? Maybe your own darling child will grow up to be a gifted violinist!

Tourist: Oh, really! You know, I've always hoped something would catch the little ones' attention!

Barcarola: ...

No one mentions the music, no one praises the melody—not a single note of it.

All they do is babble on about the violin she's holding.

They try to guess what kind of wood was used, how it was crafted, and which luthier's name is etched into the sound box.

Barcarola: Here you go.

Barcarola: It's been a while since we hung out, what with classes and practice keeping me busy all the time.

Street Artist: What's with this all of a sudden?

Street Artist: Thanks. You're not the only one at fault here, I mean—I haven't come knocking for you either, recently.

Street Artist: To tell the truth, I felt kind of embarrassed. Your family's so famous, so I was always worried I might be disturbing you.

Street Artist: But then I heard you were planning to leave Cremona to join a cruise ship. Now that really took me by surprise.

Street Artist: Anyways, I'm glad you're still here! You're a Stradivari! You couldn't possibly go off and do something so ridiculous.

She gives Barcarola's shoulder a relieved pat.

The girl's delicate shoulder trembles under the weight of each pat.

Barcarola: ...

Street Artist: Come on. It's alright. We all do stupid things sometimes, don't we?

Street Artist: The past is the past, my dear friend.

Barcarola: Yeah, that's all over now.

Barcarola: Addio. I'll see you later.

She walks toward the alley.

She retraces her steps across the ground, passing the stone steps where she briefly stopped.

She finds a quiet spot and lowers herself to the ground.

Barcarola: The monotony ... It's unbearable ...

Barcarola: ...

I fear the coming daylight might just keep me here.

Life's journey offers me poetry and song.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310811

The concert is almost over. The young woman on the stage releases the final notes from her Crackling Box, allowing them to flutter into the air.

But just as the audience stands ready to head back to their cabins, she unfolds a piece of paper she had earlier tucked away.

Barcarola: The last song of the evening.

Barcarola: For a traveler, who shares my homeland.

Barcarola: Please, everyone, hold on just a moment.

She gently places the Crackling Box down, then walks briskly toward the stage's edge.

The sailor waiting there hands her a violin.

Guest: A violin?

Guest: Could it be that she's from Cremona? Could this be a creation from Cremona's most famous bottega?

Cruise Ticket Seller: Why don't you listen with your own ears and see if you can tell?

Cruise Ticket Seller: With your kind of expertise, it's no wonder that you'd recognize it.

Whispers ripple through the crowd below.

The audience directs their attention to the young musician standing at the center of the stage.

What piece is most fitting for this violin?

It should be a song often heard in her homeland, one performed by musicians on the side of the street.

Flowing like a small boat drifting downstream, a memory of peace and serenity.

"Home."

Upon hearing this word, the first thing to enter her mind is this melody.

As this is to be the farewell song for the evening. The crew positions themselves at the exits, ready to usher the guests away.

All applause and praise are hushed, not a single soul present daring to disturb the melody or drown out the notes.

Guest: Ah, this is the song.

Guest: The first Neapolitan song ever translated into Italian. I heard it often as a child.

Guest: At the time, I never thought of it as something so wondrous.

Guest: But now, so many years away from my hometown, I've never heard it performed like this.

Cruise Ticket Seller: So, you might say you're satisfied with this performance, sì?

Cruise Ticket Seller: Be sure to recommend the "Free Breeze" to all your friends and family!

Guest: Naturally! I'll tell everyone I know about this ship and its talented musicians.

Guest: I think I'll stay a bit longer before going back to my room. I don't want to miss a single note.

Guest: I'll stay until the very last note.

Cruise Ship Musician: It's time for me to go and practice. The whole orchestra will be rehearsing tomorrow.

Cruise Ship Musician: When Barcarola wakes up in the morning, we can rehearse again.

The two crew members step through the door, one after the other.

The deck is nearly empty, with only a few travelers remaining to enjoy the night air.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Didn't you say you were leaving the band this week to go back to your hometown?

Cruise Ticket Seller: Have you mentioned it to the captain and the others yet?

Cruise Ship Musician: I'm postponing my vacation. The captain shared something with me.

Cruise Ship Musician: He found someone to take over the ship, and our new course has already been decided.

Cruise Ticket Seller: Wherever the ship takes me, I'm happy to go.

Cruise Ticket Seller: I wonder if our new destination will have any decent taverne.

Cruise Ship Musician: Perhaps not, since it is quite a small island.

Cruise Ship Musician: But I've heard that the people on the island have a special custom of wearing shells. Maybe we'll have a chance to drink from one!

Cruise Ship Musician: Or something like—hm?

She hears a faint noise through the door and signals for her companion to be quiet.

The sea breeze almost sweeps the gentle melody away.

Barcarola: Inside the tents, putting aside supper.

Barcarola: On such a quiet evening.

Barcarola: On such a quiet evening.

Barcarola: Who wouldn't demand, who wouldn't desire?

Barcarola: Santa Lucia, Santa Lucia.

The bottega hostess listens to the entire song and rewinds the tape to the start.

Cremona is seldom this silent.

Where is her ship headed, and when will her next letter home arrive?

All she can do is wish her child well.

Barcarola: On the sea glitters the silver star.

Barcarola: Gentle the waves, favorable the winds.

Barcarola: Come into my nimble little boat.

Barcarola: Santa Lucia, Santa Lucia.